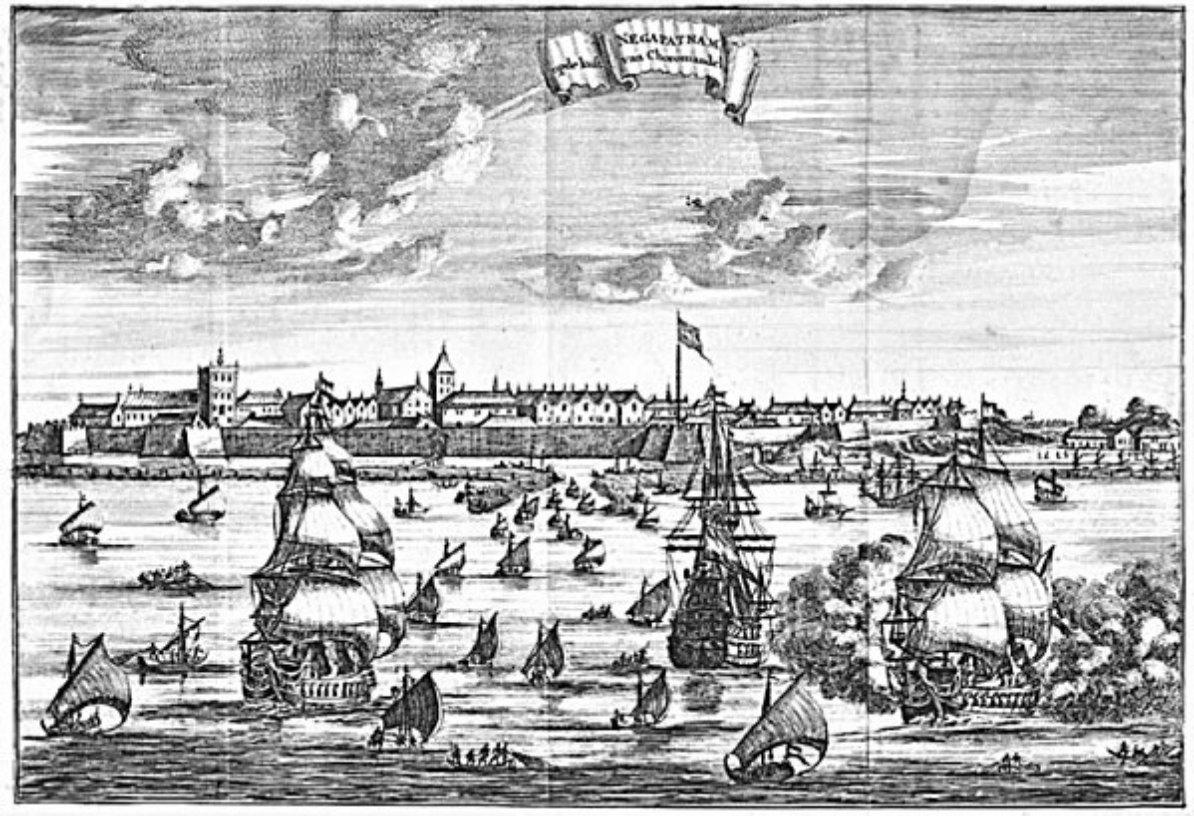
When Ludovico di Varthema's *Itinerario* was published in Rome in 1510 every copy was snapped up. Up to that point the Portuguese had successfully guarded the trade secrets of their navigation in the Indies. Thanks in part to Ludovico's descriptions of India's eastern seaboard, the coast of Coromandel now became a target for Portugal's maritime rivals: the Dutch, Danes, French and English. It was the Dutch, through the Vereenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie (VOC), or the Dutch East Indies Company, who went on to show the Portuguese how to trade without scruples. In 1609 they captured the Portuguese fort at Pulicat, which stands at the mouth of the Pulicat lagoon, today a placid bird sanctuary.



'Negapatnam opde kust van Choromandel'. Dutch ships off their new enclave of Nagapattinam, having just ousted the Portuguese. Engraving from Wouter Schouten's *Oost-Indische Voyagie*, first published in 1676.